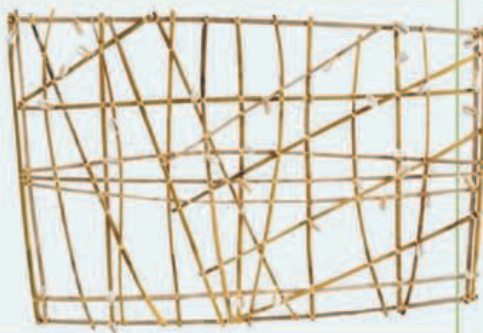


INVENTION

STICK CHART

This stick chart from the Marshall Islands, in the Pacific Ocean, demonstrates one of the many unique methods the Polynesians used to navigate the seas. Made of sticks and shells, and bearing little resemblance to a normal map, it is a representation of local tides and currents. Rather than taking the chart on voyages, Polynesian navigators memorized them prior to departure, often with the aid of chants.



their environment just as much as any other group of settlers. Polynesians arriving on new islands brought with them domesticated animals, such as dogs, chickens, and pigs, and they (along with the rats which stowed away) were highly destructive. The Polynesians also brought new plants for farming, and chopped down trees to make boats, tools, and fire. In fact, one reliable method for dating the Polynesian expansion across the Pacific is to look for archaeological evidence of large flora and fauna extinctions.

Because of this, each of the Pacific islands today has its own unique ecosystem, consisting of the different plants and animals that

happened to survive the arrival of the Polynesians, mingled with whatever invading species were introduced to the island with the colonists.

Mysteries of Rapa Nui

Rapa Nui (also known as Easter Island) is one of the most isolated islands in Polynesia. It lies 1,290 miles (2,000 km) from the nearest island and is believed to have been named Easter Island because the first European visitor arrived on Easter Sunday in 1722. Historians still do not agree

on when the Polynesians arrived; some claim it was as early as 300 CE, while recent studies claim a late date of about 1200 CE.

Archaeologists do know that around 1000–1200 CE, the trees of Rapa Nui began to disappear. Climate change

16 MILLION The number of palm trees thought to have stood on Rapa Nui before the arrival of humans.

and the arrival of seed-eating rats may have increased the speed of the decline, but it seems to have largely been triggered by the colonists' obsessive construction of giant stone heads called "Moai." These were carved in one piece from compressed volcanic ash and required wooden frameworks during the carving process, and wooden rollers for transport from the quarries to ceremonial sites along the coast.

No one knows for certain why the Moai were built, or what they represent; and as they were built over a long period of time, the tradition may have been influenced by a variety of changing

With the arrival of western ships, Polynesian isolation came to an end.

EUROPEAN CONTACTS

From 1567, European ships began to explore the islands of the South Pacific **224–25** >>. Colonists soon followed, crushing **indigenous cultures** with weapons, gods, and diseases. Some went down fighting—this spear is from the New Zealand Wars (1845–72), fought between the Maori and the British.

MAORI
SPEAR



factors. However, as the heads replaced the trees, environmental disaster struck, and Rapa Nui's ecosystem collapsed. Birds had nowhere safe to nest, so they became extinct. The loose soil washed into the sea, leaving a lifeless landscape. The inhabitants could not even build boats for fishing—they resorted to cannibalism to stay alive, and began to tear down and deface the heads that had affected their environment so much.

Moai heads

Those Moai that made it to their final destination were erected along the coast of Rapa Nui, facing inland. According to one theory, they represent great chiefs from the island's history.

